

INTERVIEW | GHULAM NABI AZAD

“The flu might be here to stay for a while, perhaps even months”

In the midst of a busy calendar when the nation is in the grip of a new and unusual global pandemic, Union Health Minister Ghulam Nabi Azad spoke to Deputy Editor DAMAYANTI DATTA. Excerpts:

Q. The H1N1 virus has arrived finally in India and is spreading fast. How scared should we be?

A. We have to be cautious, but not scared. When a scare is created, without direct contact with the object of fear, people tend to go berserk. They queue up in flu facilities, clog up resources and as a result genuine people often don't get the attention they need. Also, there's no point being scared. The flu has cut right across the globe, affecting 168 countries. As a global citizen one has to have the courage to face it. The only thing we could do—and we did—was to contain it for some time. We have been very vigilant and fared much better than most other countries, even those that spend a seventh of their GDP on health.

Q. What sort of strategies did we implement?

A. One of the most fruitful efforts has been to screen passengers at all airports—and we covered 45 lakh people in two-and-a-half months. Then possibly only India took up contact tracing. In other words, treating not just the person showing signs of infection but tracking all the people they may have come in contact with. We contacted all of them and treated them. If we hadn't done these two, by now India would have had millions of infected people. But then, you can stop it, contain it for a while but not forever.

Q. Has that time come?

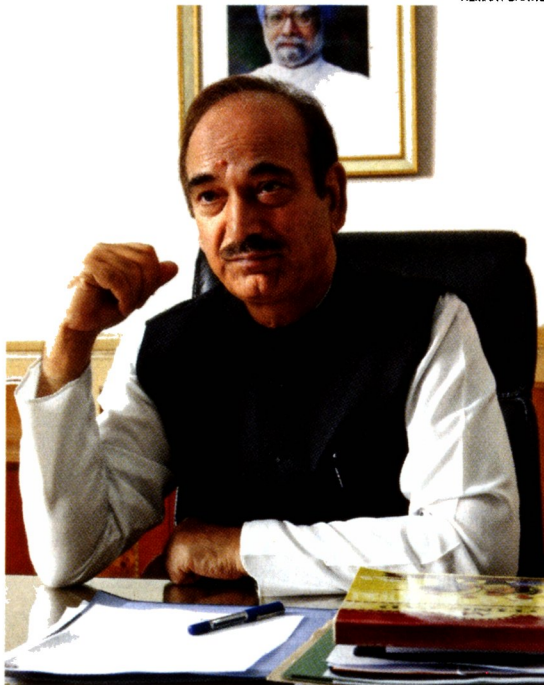
A. As long as it was humanly possible to manage the frontiers and track people for treatment, we did it. But now the time has come for a different

strategy. We are rolling out a National Preparedness Programme. We have formulated our guidelines along with eminent specialists in the field. And we are sending bureaucrats over to every state, meet and rope in all the chief ministers to make our mission a success. We are going to identify more labs in the state capitals; build capacity in public and private hospitals; train

infectious and spreads very fast. In fact, the good news is that the antiviral drug, Tamiflu, works like magic. Most of the fatalities you have heard of happened because of delay in treatment.

Q. And we have enough stock?

A. Please remember that this is the first phase of the pandemic and hence milder in nature. It may come back in a more virulent form. So the WHO says



HEMANT CHAWLA

“It is definitely not a killer. In India, the death rate from other diseases is much higher than that from H1N1.”

doctors and other manpower; keep enough stock of personal protective equipment; involve the private sector for tertiary diagnostic purposes, etc. We are going to start a dedicated interactive website only on swine flu.

Q. How severe is this outbreak?

A. It's not deadly at all. It's definitely not a killer. In our country thousands of people die because of other diseases every day. So number-wise it's no different from them. The only difference from other influenza is that it is highly

that if you get a milder attack you needn't take the medicine. We have enough to see us through any crises.

Q. How worried are you about the pandemic's progress?

A. I am positive and proactive. We are trying our best. We have not given up. We are not giving up hopes so soon.

Q. How long do you expect the swine flu to linger?

A. That's very difficult to say. The WHO says it's here to stay for a while, maybe for even months.